



feature

A global recession

According to the IMF, the world economy is set to decline by between 0.5% and 1.0% in 2009 — the first global recession in 60 years

Unsocial Networking

In the context of the on-going recession, it pays to be active in the realm of business networking: make contacts, seek jobs and build your social capital

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Stories of layoffs are common the world over. Does this mean there are no jobs at all? Not really. It's only a matter of being spotted. Sure, you probably have your resume uploaded on job portals, but in this cut-throat, competitive time that's not nearly enough. You need to build contacts, get noticed — basically, you need to network. Professional networking increases your chances of finding a job. And if you're one of those fortunate enough to already have a job — and are probably *holding on* to it — the contacts you make via professional networking will go a long way.

So what are the web sites in the domain of business networking, and what do they have to offer? One of the most popular ones in India is LinkedIn. Apart from LinkedIn, many headhunters use resources such as Siliconindia, Ryze, Konnects, Xing.com and JobsINBOX to scout for talent. "One of the main advantages that web sites such as LinkedIn offer is a platform for you to showcase your credentials to the world while being subtle. It's less obvious than putting up a profile on job sites," says a partner at a well known search firm. (Considering the secrecy of process and the seriousness with which such firms look at privacy, no one we spoke to wished to be named). Having a professional profile with one of these networks is considered perfectly normal.

As for the multitude of web sites offering business and professional networking services, they all are pretty much the same. Some are more user friendly than

others, and hence attract more users. More users, in turn, increase their functionality. LinkedIn, for instance, has 35 million registered users worldwide. There are some networks intended specifically for certain industry verticals. Ryze.com gained a lot of momentum with entrepreneurs at one point in time because of the offline meets it used to conduct in local cities, thereby bridging the gap between online and actual networking.

With the coming of LinkedIn, Ryze quickly fell off the popularity charts because it was pretty unwieldy to operate. Verkko.in is another vertical-oriented networking web site. It is a group of closed community networks for premier Indian business schools. Being actively managed, it is directed at delivering tailored jobs to its members. Its co-founder Vikhyat Srivastava calls his brand of connecting people "value networking".

Another popular web site is **siliconindia.com** which caters to most verticals, not just the IT audience, as its name might suggest. The web site claims to now have over 2 million registered users. We did a random search and found several hundred people in the media industry listed. It is famous for its blogs and for the unique mentor-apprentice system it follows. Other worthy mentions are **ibsbros.com** a portal for ICFAI business schools, and **Caclubindia.com**, an exclu-

sive chartered accountants' network.

There are also service providers such as **CollectiveX.com** and **Ning.com**, which allow you to host your own little business or professional network. So you can actually call it a *network of networks*. It's a great networking tool for specific situations. For instance, if you happen to be hosting or attending a conference and want the members to break the ice and get familiar even before the actual seminar. Ideas can be tossed around, discussions conducted, bulletins and updates sent out before starting the actual event. It can even be used as a company intranet or a specialised alumni group. In fact, a pan-IIM alumni group is hosted on CollectiveX.

The operating philosophy of each of these web sites is also different. Some allow free communication and connectivity between their users, while some such as LinkedIn are more guarded. You cannot just add people randomly — you need to know them. This is established at the time of sending a request by verifying how you know the person you intend to connect with. In extreme cases, the users' email ID is requested. If several of your requests are rejected by people indicating they don't know you, you then have to compulsorily enter the recipient's email ID. Perhaps it's due to this emphasis on user privacy, that LinkedIn is popular.

How do such networks work and what do you need to know to get them to work for you? To get started, create a profile by giving relevant details of your educational and professional career path till date. How much information you give is entirely up to you, but remember to play by certain rules. Your online profile is like your resume — so be honest. A reasonable expectation among

CONNECTIONS



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